Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 2 · DAYS 17-28

Common Grace and the Noahic Covenant

Genesis 4-11

Sin spreads; God preserves creation for the sake of redemption.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD."

GENESIS 6:8

Psalms 9, 33:10-22, and 36:5-12 on God's care for the world and his judgment of the nations.

UNIT 2

In this unit

WEEK 3

17	Genesis 4:1-26	*Reading*
18	Genesis 5:1-32	*Reading*
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WEEK 4

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DAY 17 · WEEK 3

Genesis 4:1-26

Cain and Abel; sin crouching at the door; the line of Seth

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Reading · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 4:1-26 slowly. This is the first chapter after the Fall, and it shows immediately what sin does in the second generation. Notice the contrast between the two brothers, the warning God gives Cain before the murder, and the closing note about people calling on the name of the LORD.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Unit 1 ended with Adam and Eve being driven from the garden. The first promise of redemption had been given, the offspring of the woman would one day crush the serpent's head, but the immediate landscape was bleak. Today's reading is what happens next. Genesis 4 is the first chapter of life east of Eden. It shows us a world where the consequences of sin are not theoretical but lethal, and where God is still speaking, still warning, still naming his people.

This unit covers Genesis 4 through 11, the early chapters of human history before Abraham, sometimes called the "primeval history." These chapters trace the spread of sin from one family to all humanity, and the response of a patient God who preserves creation for the sake of his redemptive purposes.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Eve names Cain with what appears to be hope: "I have gotten a man with the help of the LORD." Some scholars see her hoping that Cain might be the promised offspring of Genesis 3:15.
2. Cain brings "of the fruit of the ground"; Abel brings "of the firstborn of his flock and of their fat portions." The text does not condemn agriculture, but it does say God "had regard for Abel and his offering" but "for Cain and his offering he had no regard."

3. God does not abandon Cain when his sacrifice is rejected. He warns him: “sin is crouching at the door. Its desire is for you, but you must rule over it.”
4. Cain does not respond to God’s warning. The first murder follows, and it happens to a brother, not to a stranger or an enemy.
5. When God asks Cain where his brother is, Cain echoes the deflection of his parents in Eden: “Am I my brother’s keeper?”
6. The blood of Abel “cries out from the ground”, the Hebrew is plural, “bloods”, suggesting not just Abel’s life but all his potential descendants who will never be.
7. Lamech (4:23-24) embodies sin’s escalation: he boasts of killing a young man for striking him, and demands sevenfold-times-eleven vengeance.
8. The chapter ends, unexpectedly, on a note of hope: Seth is born, Enosh is born, “At that time people began to call upon the name of the LORD.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 4 is one of the most psychologically penetrating chapters in the Bible. In just twenty-six verses, the story moves from the first act of worship after the Fall, through the first warning about sin’s nature, into the first murder, and finally to the first sustained worship of God outside the garden. It is a chapter about what happens to humanity after the Fall, and it tells us things we need to know.

The chapter begins with two brothers and two offerings. Why was Abel’s accepted and Cain’s rejected? The text gives no detailed explanation, but the writer of Hebrews tells us “by faith Abel offered to God a more acceptable sacrifice than Cain” (Hebrews 11:4). The difference was not in the type of offering but in the heart of the worshiper. Cain went through the motions; Abel offered in faith. From the very beginning of human worship after the Fall, God has cared about the heart, not just the ritual.

Then comes God’s warning to Cain, and notice what it tells us about sin. “Sin is crouching at the door. Its desire is for you, but you must rule over it.” Sin is personified as a predator at the threshold of Cain’s heart. The language echoes Genesis 3:16, where the woman’s desire is for her husband, but he will rule over her, the language of distorted, fallen relationships. Sin is not a passive failure; it is an active force seeking to consume. And critically, God speaks to Cain about it. The first warning about indwelling sin in the Bible comes from God himself, gently, before any violence has occurred. God is not absent from a fallen world; he speaks to his image-bearers even when they are angry, even when they are about to do terrible things.

But Cain does not listen. The next thing he does is invite his brother to a field and kill him. The first murder in human history is a fratricide. This is significant. The Bible does not present sin as an abstract problem; it presents it as something that ruptures the most intimate relationships. The first violence is not war between nations but a brother killing a brother. From this point forward, every act of human violence will be, in some sense, an echo of Cain, the strong against the weak, the older against the younger, the resentful against the favored, all of us against one another, all of us forgetting that the person we strike is our kin.

When God confronts Cain, Cain replies with the most famous deflection in Scripture: "Am I my brother's keeper?" The answer, of course, is yes. You are. Every human is the keeper of every other human, because all bear the image of God. Cain's question contains its own indictment.

Then God speaks of Abel's blood crying out from the ground. The Hebrew uses the plural form, bloods, which Jewish tradition has long understood as including not only Abel himself but all the descendants he would have had. Every murder is a multiplication, a cutting off of countless lives that would have come. The earth itself, the very ground that received Adam's body in the garden, now testifies against violence.

And then we see Cain's lineage drift further away from God. By the time we reach Lamech (verses 23-24), sin has metastasized. Lamech kills a man for merely striking him, and boasts about it to his wives in a poem. He invokes the principle of measured vengeance that God had used to protect Cain, "if Cain's revenge is sevenfold, then Lamech's is seventy-sevenfold", and weaponizes it for his own ego. Sin not only spreads; it amplifies. Each generation, left to itself, escalates the cycle.

But the chapter does not end there. Verse 25 brings Seth, the replacement for Abel. And verse 26 brings a single beautiful sentence: "At that time people began to call upon the name of the LORD." Even in the depth of human degradation, even in the first generations after exile from Eden, there is a remnant, people who worship. The story of redemption is the story of this remnant, called by God, kept by God, leading through generations all the way to Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Unit 1 told us what humanity was meant to be (Genesis 1-2) and what humanity became (Genesis 3). Genesis 4 is the immediate aftermath. The covenant of works was broken, the curse was pronounced, the gospel was promised, and now we begin to see what life under those conditions actually looks like. The seed of the woman (Genesis 3:15) is still in view: Cain is rejected as the promised one, Abel is killed, but Seth is born to continue the godly line, and his son Enosh leads people to call on the name of the LORD. The line of promise will

run through Seth, then through Noah, then through Abraham, then through David, all the way to Christ. The first hint that God's redemptive plan will be preserved despite human violence appears in the very chapter where the first violence happens.

STEP 6

Application

Listen to God's warning to Cain, it is a warning to you. "Sin is crouching at the door. Its desire is for you, but you must rule over it." This is a profound psychological insight. Sin in the believer's life is not a one-time event but a persistent presence, waiting at the doorway of every heart, looking for an opportunity. The Christian life is not the absence of temptation; it is the daily ruling over sin by the Spirit's power.

Practically, where is sin crouching at your door today? Maybe it is bitterness toward someone. Maybe it is a habitual indulgence. Maybe it is anger you have been nursing. Maybe it is comparison or envy or the slow drift away from prayer. The point is not to be paranoid, it is to be honest. God spoke to Cain before the murder. He still speaks to his people before the sin. Are you listening?

And take Cain's deflection seriously. "Am I my brother's keeper?" In a world that is happy to pretend we are not responsible for each other, the Christian remembers: every person you encounter bears the image of God, and you are accountable for how you treat them. This applies to your closest family and your most distant neighbor. The blood of Abel still cries out from the ground when we forget this.

But take heart from verse 26. Even in the worst of times, "people began to call upon the name of the LORD." The remnant is always there. The line of promise is always preserved. The faithful worship of God always survives, even when the world is sliding into Lamech's violence. You are part of that continuing remnant. Today, call upon his name.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to show you where sin is crouching at your door, and tell him the truth about it.
- Confess any place you have deflected blame or refused to care for another person.
- Thank him that he is merciful even in the darkest chapters.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 3

“But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD.”

GENESIS 6:8

DAY 18 · WEEK 3

Genesis 5:1-32

The genealogy of Adam, life, death, and the promise preserved

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Reading · 32 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 5:1-32 slowly. Yes, this is a genealogy, and it may feel like one of those passages that's tempting to skim. Don't. Genealogies in Scripture are theological documents. As you read, notice the repeated phrase "and he died," the curious exception in verse 24, and the way the chapter ends in suspense.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday we read about the first murder and the spread of sin from one generation to the next. Genesis 5 takes a step back and gives us the full genealogy of Adam through Noah, ten generations from creation to the flood. It is one of the most important genealogies in the Bible, and it sets up everything that comes next. This is also the first genealogy of Scripture, and it teaches us how to read all the ones that follow.

Genealogies are not filler. They are theological records. They tell us who is in the line of promise, how God's faithfulness has been transmitted from generation to generation, and how the world fits together as one story. This genealogy in particular establishes that there is an unbroken line from Adam to Noah, that humanity has been multiplying across the earth, that death has been spreading along with humanity, and that one man in particular, Enoch, escaped death by walking with God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 1 explicitly recalls Genesis 1:27: God "made him in the likeness of God. Male and female he created them, and he blessed them." The image of God survived the Fall, humanity still bears it.
2. Adam's first descendant is described differently from himself: "Adam … fathered a son in his own likeness, after his image, and named him Seth." The image of God is now

mediated through fallen humanity.

3. Each generation follows a strict formula: [Name] lived X years, fathered [Son], lived Y more years, fathered other sons and daughters, and the years of his life were Z, AND HE DIED.
4. The phrase “and he died” appears eight times. Death, the consequence promised in Genesis 2:17, has come true and is now the universal human experience.
5. Enoch is the seventh from Adam and breaks the pattern. He “walked with God, and he was not, for God took him.” He does not die.
6. Lamech (a different Lamech than Cain’s descendant) names his son Noah, saying “this one shall give us rest from our work and from the painful toil of our hands because of the ground that the LORD has cursed.”
7. The genealogy ends not with “and he died” for Noah, but with the open-ended note that he “had three sons”, Shem, Ham, and Japheth. The story is not over yet.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 5 looks like a list, but it is preaching. The whole chapter is built around a tension: the image of God in humanity, and the reality of death that now follows every human life. Both are true. The chapter holds them together and lets us feel the weight.

Verse 1 deliberately echoes Genesis 1:27. “When God created man, he made him in the likeness of God. Male and female he created them, and he blessed them when they were created.” After the Fall and after Cain’s violence, the writer wants us to remember: humanity is still in the image of God. The Fall did not erase the image. It marred it, but it did not destroy it. Every person born to Adam and Eve, including Cain, bears the image of God. And this matters because the image will run through this chapter, generation by generation, all the way to Noah and beyond.

But then verse 3 introduces a haunting modification. Seth is born, and the text says Adam “fathered a son in his own likeness, after his image.” The phrase has shifted. Adam was made in God’s image; Seth is made in Adam’s image. The image is now mediated through fallen humanity. This is the doctrine of original sin being expressed not through theological argument but through narrative shading. The image survives. But it is now passed down through people who have already inherited the corruption of the Fall. Every child born is in the image of God and in the image of fallen Adam at the same time.

Then comes the repeated rhythm of the chapter: "and he died." Eight times. Each life recorded, each life ended. The chapter is, in one sense, a long funeral. The promise of Genesis 2:17, "in the day you eat of it you shall surely die", is being slowly, generation by generation, fulfilled. Death is not just an unfortunate biological fact; it is a theological reality. It is the consequence of sin. And it is now woven into the fabric of human existence.

This is what makes Enoch's story so stunning. Verse 24: "Enoch walked with God, and he was not, for God took him." Enoch is the seventh from Adam, and seven is the number of completeness, of fullness, and he breaks the pattern. He does not die. The text does not explain how or why, but the phrase "walked with God" appears only twice in the Old Testament about an individual: about Enoch here and about Noah in Genesis 6:9. The implication is clear: there is a kind of life that escapes the universal sentence of death. There is a way of relating to God that transforms what death does to a person. Hebrews 11:5 puts it this way: "By faith Enoch was taken up so that he should not see death." Enoch is the first hint in Scripture that death is not the final word, even though death has come for everyone else, there is one who walks with God and bypasses the grave entirely.

The chapter then comes to its climax with Lamech and Noah. Lamech names his son Noah, which sounds like the Hebrew word for "rest." And he explains the name: "this one shall give us rest from our work and from the painful toil of our hands because of the ground that the LORD has cursed." Lamech is reaching back to Genesis 3:17, where the ground was cursed because of Adam's sin, and he is hoping, perhaps even prophesying, that this child will somehow lift the curse. He doesn't fully grasp what he is saying. Noah will not lift the curse permanently. But Noah will be the means by which God preserves humanity through the flood, and through Noah's line the true rest-giver will eventually come. The line of promise runs from Adam to Seth to Enosh to Enoch to Noah, and from there, all the way to Christ, who alone gives true rest to the weary.

STEP 5

Connection

Yesterday's reading showed sin spreading after the Fall, from Cain's anger to Lamech's vengeance. Today's chapter shows the bigger picture: ten generations of human history, with death claiming each one in turn. This is the world that the gospel will eventually answer. The promise of Genesis 3:15 (the offspring of the woman) is being preserved through a particular family line, Seth, Enosh, and onward to Noah, and ultimately to Abraham and David and Christ. Enoch's escape from death foreshadows the resurrection. Lamech's hope for rest through Noah foreshadows the deeper rest we have in Jesus. Even a genealogy is gospel-shaped when you know how to read it.

STEP 6

Application

The repeated phrase “and he died” is meant to land on you. Every human life that has ever been lived will end with that phrase. Yours will too. The Bible does not let you forget this, because pretending death is not coming is one of the most spiritually corrosive habits a human can have. Death is real. It is the consequence of sin. And it will claim you.

But Enoch is in this chapter for a reason. Enoch walked with God, and death did not have its way with him. The Christian message is not that death is unreal or that we should be brave about it. The Christian message is that death has been conquered by the one who walked with God perfectly, Jesus, and that those who are in him will follow him through death into life. Hebrews 11 lists Enoch among the heroes of faith because his story is a sign: there is a way of relating to God that changes what death does to you.

Today, ask yourself: am I walking with God? Not perfectly, Enoch alone is described that way among ordinary humans, but truly. Is my life a daily walk with the God who made me, redeemed me, and is sanctifying me? Or have I drifted into a religious routine that does not feel like walking with anyone? The phrase “walked with God” appears precious few times in Scripture. It is offered to you. Take it up.

And if you have lost someone, or are afraid of losing someone, or are afraid of your own death, let Genesis 5 do its work in two directions. Yes, death is real. Yes, it is coming. But the same chapter that records death also records Enoch, who walked with God and was taken. In Christ, that is the trajectory of every believer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his image still marks you, and tell him how you feel when you think about death.

Ask him to help you walk with him as Enoch did, day by day.

Thank Christ that death is not the end for those who are his.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 3

“But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD.”

GENESIS 6:8

DAY 19 · WEEK 3

Genesis 6:1-22

The corruption of creation; Noah finds grace; the ark commanded

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Reading · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 6:1-22 slowly. This is one of the most sobering chapters in the Bible. It contains both the grimmest assessment of human depravity in the Old Testament and the first glimpse of God's grace toward a particular man. As you read, notice the contrast between verses 5 and 8.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday we walked through ten generations from Adam to Noah, watching death claim each generation in turn while the line of promise quietly continued. Today we arrive at the crisis point. Sin has not just spread, it has saturated. The world God called "very good" in Genesis 1 has become a world God grieves over in Genesis 6. The chapter we read today is the prelude to the flood. It is also the chapter where the word "grace" first appears in the Bible.

The chapter has several unusual features that have puzzled interpreters for centuries, the sons of God taking the daughters of men, the Nephilim, the lifespan limit of 120 years. These are real interpretive challenges, but they are not the point of the chapter. The point is this: humanity has become so corrupt that God will start over, but one man has found grace.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The chapter opens with a strange episode (verses 1-4) about the "sons of God" taking the "daughters of man" as wives. Many interpretations exist; the text itself is sparse.
2. Verse 3: "My Spirit shall not abide in man forever, for he is flesh: his days shall be 120 years." This may be a divine deadline before the flood, or a general statement on human lifespan.

3. Verse 5 is one of the bleakest assessments of humanity in the Bible: "every intention of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually."
4. Verse 6 attributes genuine emotion to God: he was "grieved" and his heart "was sorrowful." God is not impassive in the face of human sin.
5. Verse 8 is the hinge of the chapter: "But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD." The Hebrew word for "favor" here is hen, the first appearance of the word grace in Scripture.
6. Noah is described as "a righteous man, blameless in his generation. Noah walked with God." The same phrase used of Enoch.
7. The ark's dimensions are precise: 300 cubits long, 50 wide, 30 high. Roughly 450 feet by 75 feet by 45 feet.
8. God establishes a "covenant" with Noah (verse 18) before the flood comes, the first explicit use of the word covenant in the Bible.
9. The chapter ends: "Noah did this; he did all that God commanded him." Obedience born of grace.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 6 is one of the most theologically loaded chapters in the entire Bible. In just twenty-two verses, we see the depth of human sin, the genuine sorrow of God, the first mention of grace, the introduction of the word covenant, and the obedience of one man who walks with God against the entire grain of his culture.

The chapter opens with a mysterious passage (verses 1-4) about the "sons of God" who take the "daughters of man" as wives, producing offspring described as Nephilim and "mighty men of old, men of renown." Three main interpretations have been offered through church history: that the sons of God were fallen angels, that they were powerful human rulers, or that they were descendants of the godly line of Seth intermarrying with the corrupt line of Cain. The text itself is sparse, and good Christian interpreters have differed. What matters for our purposes is the result: a further escalation of human corruption that prompts God's verdict in verse 3 and his action in verses 5-7.

Verse 5 is the most devastating sentence in the Old Testament about the human condition. "The LORD saw that the wickedness of man was great in the earth, and that every intention of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually." Every intention. Of the thoughts. Of

the heart. Only evil. Continually. This is total depravity in narrative form. The doctrine of sin you read about on Day 6 is not a theological abstraction; it is what God himself saw when he looked at his creation a few generations after Adam.

And then comes one of the most surprising verses in the Old Testament. Verse 6: "And the LORD was sorry that he had made man on the earth, and it grieved him to his heart." This is not the cool, detached God of philosophy. This is a God who genuinely feels. He grieves over what humanity has become. He is sorrowful over the broken relationship with his image-bearers. We must be careful not to read this as a God who was surprised, the same Bible insists that God knows the end from the beginning. But we must also not flatten this into a metaphor. The God of the Bible has real affections, and human sin really grieves him.

Then verse 8, in the middle of the catastrophe: "But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD." The conjunction is everything. The world is drowning in evil, and God is grieving, BUT Noah found grace. The Hebrew word translated "favor" is hen, which appears here for the first time in Scripture and will run through the entire Old Testament as the language of unmerited divine kindness. Notice carefully what the text does not say. It does not say Noah earned God's favor or deserved God's favor. It says he found it. Grace, by definition, is found, not earned. And then it tells us what kind of man Noah was: righteous, blameless in his generation, walking with God. This is not the basis of his grace; it is the fruit of it. Noah's righteousness is what grace had made of him in a world where everyone else was evil.

The rest of the chapter is the introduction of a new covenant arrangement. God reveals his judgment plan to Noah, gives him precise instructions for the ark, and says: "I will establish my covenant with you" (verse 18). This is the first use of the word "covenant" (berith) in the Bible. From this point on, covenant will be the central category of biblical theology. God always relates to his people through covenant, first with Noah, then with Abraham, then with Israel at Sinai, then with David, and finally through the new covenant in Christ. Genesis 6 is where this great covenantal story begins.

The chapter ends with a single, climactic sentence: "Noah did this; he did all that God commanded him." It would have taken many decades to build the ark. The world was watching, probably mocking. There was no rain yet, Noah was building a sea-going vessel inland, on God's word alone. And he did everything God commanded. This is what faith looks like when grace meets a person: obedience that does not need to see results before it acts.

STEP 5

Connection

Yesterday's genealogy showed the line of promise being preserved through Seth and his descendants. Genesis 6 narrows the focus to one man, Noah. The doctrine of sin you encountered on Day 6 is here demonstrated in its most extreme form: every intention of the human heart was only evil continually. And the doctrine of grace, which the rest of the Bible will develop, makes its first explicit appearance: "Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD." From the very beginning of Scripture, the pattern is set, humanity in rebellion, God in patient grief, and one chosen by grace to receive what others cannot. This pattern will repeat with Abraham, with Israel, and ultimately in Christ, who alone is the truly righteous one through whom all who are in him are preserved through the judgment to come.

STEP 6

Application

Sit with verse 5 for a moment before you move on. "Every intention of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually." This is what God saw when he looked at humanity then, and it is what God still sees when he looks at humanity now apart from his grace. Not just bad behavior on the surface, but evil running all the way down to the intentions of the heart. This is not exaggeration. It is what your Maker sees.

And sit with verse 8. "But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD." Grace is the only difference between you and the world headed for judgment. Not your morality, your church attendance, your good intentions, your spiritual disciplines, your theology. Grace. God's free, unearned, unmerited choice to set his favor on you in Christ.

Today, consider three things. First, take your own sin seriously. The same evil that filled the earth in Noah's day is still in human hearts, yours included. Do not minimize what God grieves over. Second, take grace seriously. You did not find God; he found you. Whatever righteousness has been worked in your life is the fruit of grace, not its cause. Be humble about it. Third, take obedience seriously. Noah heard God's word and obeyed in a world that thought he was crazy. If you are following Christ today in ways that confuse or anger people around you, you are in good company. Build your ark. The flood is real. And Christ is the door.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what you see in your own heart when you look honestly at it.

Thank him for the grace that has found you apart from any merit of your own.

Ask him for the kind of obedience Noah showed, even when it looks foolish to others.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 3

“But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD.”

GENESIS 6:8

DAY 20 · WEEK 3

Genesis 7:1-8:19

The flood, judgment and preservation; God remembers Noah

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Reading · 57 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 7:1-8:19. This is the flood narrative itself, one of the longest single readings of Unit 2. Read steadily; don't get lost in the technical details of the chronology. The heart of the passage is the rhythm of judgment and preservation, and the great pivot in chapter 8:1: "But God remembered Noah."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday we saw God's verdict on the corrupt earth and his choice of Noah to be the one through whom humanity would be preserved. Today we read the flood itself. This is one of the most well-known stories in the Bible, but it is much more than a children's story about animals on a boat. Genesis 7-8 is a theological meditation on judgment and grace, on the de-creation and re-creation of the world, on God's commitment to preserve what he has made even while he judges what has gone wrong with it.

As you read, watch for the deliberate echoes of Genesis 1. The waters above and below come unbound. The breath of life is taken from creatures. Then, on the other side, the waters subside, dry land appears, the breath of life returns to creatures, and humanity emerges to be fruitful and multiply. This is not just a story about a flood. It is a story about creation itself starting over.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God's instruction in 7:1 is intimate: "Go into the ark, you and all your household, for I have seen that you are righteous before me in this generation."
2. Pairs of animals come in by twos for unclean animals, but by sevens for clean animals, anticipating Noah's later sacrifice.

3. Noah was 600 years old when the flood came (7:6). The text takes the long lifespans of Genesis 5 seriously.
4. The waters come from two directions: "the fountains of the great deep burst forth, and the windows of the heavens were opened" (7:11). This is a reversal of Genesis 1, where God separated the waters above from the waters below.
5. The rain falls for 40 days; the waters prevail for 150 days. The flood is not a brief thunderstorm; it is a sustained judgment.
6. Genesis 7:21-23 echoes Genesis 1 in reverse: every creature, every kind of life, on the land, perishes. De-creation.
7. Chapter 8:1 is the hinge: "But God remembered Noah and all the beasts and all the livestock that were with him in the ark." God does not forget the righteous in judgment.
8. God sends a "wind" (Hebrew ruach, also "spirit") over the earth, and the waters subside. This echoes Genesis 1:2.
9. Noah's first reconnaissance is a raven, then a dove. The dove returns with an olive leaf, life is returning to the earth.
10. When the family finally leaves the ark, they emerge into a world that, in many ways, mirrors the original creation.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The flood is one of the most theologically rich narratives in the Old Testament. To read it as merely a disaster story is to miss almost everything that matters. Genesis 7-8 is a story about creation, judgment, and new creation. Every detail is shaped by the larger biblical pattern, and once you see the pattern, the story becomes much more than a tale of survival.

First, the flood is a deliberate undoing of creation. Look back at Genesis 1. On Day 2, God separated the waters above from the waters below by placing the firmament between them. He made dry land appear. He populated the air with birds, the seas with fish, the land with animals. The world is a place of order, where the waters of chaos are held back so that life can flourish.

Now read Genesis 7:11 again. "The fountains of the great deep burst forth, and the windows of the heavens were opened." The waters above are no longer separated from the waters below. The firmament has been overwhelmed. The world is collapsing back into the chaotic, uninhabitable state of Genesis 1:2, "the earth was without form and void, and darkness was over the face of the deep." The flood is not just a natural disaster; it is creation reversing itself. Sin has so deeply corrupted the world that God allows the world to slide back toward

the chaos from which he originally rescued it. Verse 23 makes this explicit: every creature, every breath, every form of land-based life is "blotted out." The earth becomes, again, what it was before God spoke.

But not entirely. In the ark, a wooden box floating on the waters, a remnant of creation is preserved. One man, one family, pairs of every creature, the seeds of plant life, the breath of God in living things. The ark is a microcosm of the world, a fragment of creation rescued from the chaos. Some theologians have called it "creation in miniature." It is the means by which God preserves what he will then renew.

Then comes the most beautiful sentence in the entire narrative. Genesis 8:1: "But God remembered Noah and all the beasts and all the livestock that were with him in the ark." When the Bible says God "remembered" someone, it does not mean he had forgotten and then recalled. It means he is now acting on what he has known all along. God remembered Abraham, and brought Israel out of Egypt. God remembered Hannah, and gave her a son. God remembered his covenant, and acted to keep it. When God "remembers" Noah, it is the moment of grace breaking through judgment. The flood has done its work. Now the new creation can begin.

And the new creation echoes the first creation in beautiful, deliberate ways. A wind (ruach) blows over the waters, just as the Spirit (ruach) hovered over the waters in Genesis 1:2. The waters subside. Dry land appears. The breath of life returns to creatures. The dove brings back a green leaf, vegetation has survived. Noah and his family emerge from the ark into a world that, in its broad outlines, looks like the world God first made. The flood narrative ends not with destruction but with creation renewed.

This pattern, of de-creation through judgment and re-creation through grace, is one of the most important patterns in all of Scripture. It will reappear in the Exodus (Israel passes through the chaotic waters of the Red Sea into a new identity). It will reappear in the prophets (the exile is a kind of flood, and the return is a kind of new creation). It will reappear in the New Testament (baptism is a passage through water that pictures death and new life). And it will reach its climax at the end of Scripture (the present world is judged, and a new heavens and new earth emerge). The flood is the first major preview of how God works in history. Judgment and grace, death and resurrection, the old order undone and a new order rising. This is the pattern of the gospel itself.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 6 introduced Noah and the ark; today we see God's judgment fall and his preservation work. The pattern established here, de-creation through judgment, re-creation through grace, will run through the entire Bible. The Exodus will be a flood-like deliverance

(Israel passes through chaotic waters into a new identity). Baptism will be a flood-like ritual (the believer passes through water into new life with Christ). And the consummation of all things in Revelation will be the final undoing of the present order and the emergence of new heavens and new earth. When Peter writes that "baptism, which corresponds to this, now saves you" (1 Peter 3:21), he is making this exact connection. Noah is a type of every believer who is brought safely through judgment in the ark of God's grace.

STEP 6

Application

The flood is a sobering picture, but it is meant to comfort believers as much as it warns sinners. Two applications follow from this.

First, take judgment seriously. The God of Genesis 7 is the same God of the New Testament. He is patient, slow to anger, abundant in mercy, but he is not indifferent to evil. Peter explicitly draws the lesson in 2 Peter 3, comparing the flood that came on the ancient world to the judgment by fire that is yet to come on this present world. Do not let the patience of God become an excuse for casualness about sin. The reason the flood didn't come for the first six hundred years of Noah's life was not that God was unconcerned. It was that God was patient. Read your Bible knowing the same is true now. We are living in the long patience of God before a final judgment that will surely come.

Second, take grace seriously. When the floodwaters come, you do not need a stronger swimming stroke. You need an ark. And the ark, as 1 Peter teaches, is Christ. To be "in Christ", joined to him by faith, hidden in him, sealed in him, is to be safe through every judgment, both temporal and eternal. The wood of the ark in Noah's day prefigured the wood of the cross. The door that God himself closed on the ark prefigures the salvation God himself secures for his people. If you are in Christ, the flood has already passed over you, judgment fell on him, not on you, and you have emerged into a new creation.

Today, ask yourself: am I in the ark? Not, do I think well of Christianity, or do I attend church, or do I believe in God in general. Am I in Christ? Have I trusted him as my refuge, my safe passage through the judgment my sin deserves? If the answer is yes, then "God remembered Noah" is a promise for you. God remembers his own. He will bring you safely through every storm, including the last one. And the world that meets you on the other side will be a renewed creation, where righteousness dwells.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he judges sin and saves sinners, and that you are among the saved.

Praise Christ as the ark who carried you through judgment.

Ask him to keep both his patience and his coming judgment real to you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 3

“But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD.”

GENESIS 6:8

DAY 21 · WEEK 3

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. The week you have just completed was a hinge week, closing Unit 1 and opening Unit 2. Take time today to let both arcs settle. The God who created in the beginning is the same God who showed grace to Noah.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD."

GENESIS 6:8

REST

Meditation

Genesis 6:8 is the first appearance of the word "grace" (Hebrew hen) in the Bible. The conjunction "But" is everything. The verses surrounding it describe the worst assessment of humanity in the Old Testament, "every intention of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually" (6:5). And then: BUT Noah found favor.

Notice what the verse does not say. It does not say Noah earned favor. It does not say Noah deserved favor. It says he FOUND it, and grace, by definition, is what is found, not what is achieved.

Say the verse with the conjunction loud in your mind. The "But" is the gospel's word. In a world of judgment, there is a "But." In a heart of rebellion, there is a "But." That "But" is the difference between being lost with the world and being saved by grace.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week was a pivot. You finished Unit 1 with Psalm 65, David's integrated meditation on creation and atonement, and the Unit 1 Review, anchored on Genesis 1:1. Then Unit 2 began. You met Cain, the first murderer, and heard God's warning that "sin is crouching at the door." You walked through the genealogy of Genesis 5, with the repeated phrase "and he died" broken only by Enoch, who walked with God. You met Noah in Genesis 6 and learned that grace is what is found, not earned. And you began the flood narrative in Genesis 7, watching judgment fall on a world that had refused God's patience.

The arc of the week is the arc of the gospel itself. Sin spreads. Judgment comes. But Noah, and ultimately Christ, finds favor with God, and through that one, others are preserved.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where do you see God's patience and his judgment held together in this week's readings? The first half of the week celebrated creation; the second half showed the spread of sin and the coming of judgment. Both are true at once. Where do you most need to remember God's patience this week? Where do you most need to remember his judgment?

How does Noah's grace prefigure the grace you have received in Christ? Noah did not deserve to be saved any more than the people who drowned. He found favor. Through one righteous man, his family was preserved through the flood. Through one righteous Man, you have been preserved through the judgment your sin deserved. Sit with this. What does it mean that you have found grace, not earned it?

What does it look like for you, today, to "walk with God" as Enoch did? The phrase appears only twice about individuals in the Old Testament, Enoch and Noah. Both lived in cultures sliding into wickedness. Both were marked by a different kind of life. What would it take for that to be true of you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the grace behind every "But God" in your own story.

Ask him to help you walk humbly and gratefully this week in a world that does not walk with him.

Rest in the favor he has shown you in Christ.

DAY 22 · WEEK 4

Genesis 8:20-9:29

The Noahic covenant; common grace; the rainbow sign

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Reading · 30 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 8:20-9:29 slowly. After the floodwaters recede, Noah disembarks and builds an altar. What follows is one of the most important covenant passages in the Old Testament, the Noahic Covenant, God's pledge to preserve creation, and the rainbow as its sign. The chapter also ends on a sober note about Noah himself, reminding us that sin survived the flood.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After a year on the ark, Noah and his family emerge into a renewed world. Today's reading covers what happens immediately after the flood, Noah's first act of worship, God's resolution never again to destroy the earth by water, the establishment of the Noahic Covenant, the institution of capital punishment for murder, the renewal of the dominion mandate, and a strange final episode involving Noah's drunkenness and his sons.

The Noahic Covenant is one of the most important covenants in the Bible, but also one of the most misunderstood. It is not a covenant of salvation; it is a covenant of preservation. It is God's commitment to maintain the natural order so that the larger story of redemption can unfold. Without the Noahic Covenant, there is no stable world in which Abraham can be called, Israel can be formed, or Christ can come. This covenant is the foundation of common grace, the kindness God shows to all people, not just to his chosen people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The first act after the flood is worship. Noah builds an altar and offers burnt offerings.
2. God "smelled the pleasing aroma" and resolved in his heart never again to curse the ground because of man. The change is in God's commitment to creation, not in humanity's heart.

3. Verse 21 candidly admits: “the intention of man’s heart is evil from his youth.” Human nature has not been reset by the flood.
4. Verse 22 establishes the rhythm of creation: “seedtime and harvest, cold and heat, summer and winter, day and night, shall not cease.” The natural world will be stable.
5. 9:1 echoes Genesis 1:28: “Be fruitful and multiply and fill the earth.” Humanity is given a new beginning.
6. 9:6 grounds the prohibition of murder in the image of God: “whoever sheds the blood of man, by man shall his blood be shed, for God made man in his own image.”
7. The covenant is established with Noah AND with “every living creature”, it is universal in scope.
8. The rainbow is the sign of the covenant, a visible promise that judgment by water will not come again.
9. The chapter ends with Noah getting drunk, his nakedness exposed, and conflict among his sons, proving that human sin survived the flood.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Noahic Covenant is one of the most theologically significant moments in the Old Testament, but it is often overlooked in favor of the more familiar covenants with Abraham, Moses, and David. Yet without the Noahic Covenant, none of those later covenants could exist. This is the covenant that holds the world together so that redemption can unfold within it.

Notice first how the section begins. Noah builds an altar and offers burnt offerings. This is the first explicit act of sacrificial worship after the flood. Before God says anything about a covenant, before any blessing is given to the new humanity, Noah worships. And God responds. Verse 21 says, “When the LORD smelled the pleasing aroma, the LORD said in his heart, “I will never again curse the ground because of man.”” The atoning sacrifice is not yet what it will be in Christ, but the principle is there: worship offered in faith elicits divine favor. God responds to sacrifice with promise.

And what a promise it is. Verse 21: “Neither will I ever again strike down every living creature as I have done. While the earth remains, seedtime and harvest, cold and heat, summer and winter, day and night, shall not cease.” This is God’s commitment to stability. The natural world will continue. The seasons will turn. The earth will produce food. Day will

follow night. This is what theologians call common grace, the kindness God extends to the entire created order, both the righteous and the wicked, simply by sustaining the conditions of life.

Why does this matter? Because the verdict on humanity has not changed. Verse 21 admits it plainly: "the intention of man's heart is evil from his youth." The flood did not reset human nature. Noah and his family are not better than the people who died. They are saved by grace, not by superior virtue. And yet, despite humanity's continued wickedness, God commits himself to preserving the world. Why? Because he is planning something larger. The flood was a temporary judgment that prefigured the final judgment to come. But before the final judgment can come, the story of redemption must unfold. The line of Seth must continue through Noah to Abraham. The nation of Israel must be formed. The prophets must speak. Christ must come. The gospel must spread to the nations. All of that requires a stable world, with seasons and harvests and history continuing. The Noahic Covenant is what makes that possible.

The covenant is then formally established in chapter 9. It has several distinctive features. First, it is universal. Verse 9 says God makes the covenant "with you and your offspring after you, and with every living creature that is with you", every bird, animal, and human, present and future. Unlike the covenant with Abraham, which is particular to a specific people, this covenant is for all humanity and all creation. Every person who has ever lived, regardless of nation or religion, is a beneficiary of the Noahic Covenant. The food they eat, the seasons they enjoy, the air they breathe, these are gifts of common grace under this covenant.

Second, it includes the prohibition of murder, grounded in the image of God (9:6). This is the principle of the sanctity of human life. Whoever sheds human blood must answer for it, "for God made man in his own image." The reasoning is theological, not pragmatic. Murder is not just a social crime; it is an attack on God's image. This verse will become the foundation for all just systems of human government, the right to life, the responsibility to defend life, the establishment of justice systems to address violence.

Third, the covenant has a sign: the rainbow. "I have set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth." Every time it rains, the rainbow is meant to remind both God and humanity of this promise. Some scholars note that the Hebrew word for "bow" is the same word used for a weapon, and that God has "hung his bow" pointing upward, as if to say his weapon of judgment has been laid down. The rainbow is God's commitment, written in the sky, that judgment by water is over.

Then comes the strange and sobering closing scene. Noah, the righteous one through whom humanity was preserved, gets drunk and lies naked in his tent. His son Ham sees him and apparently mocks him. His other sons cover him without looking. When Noah wakes, he

curses Ham's son Canaan. This passage has been misused throughout church history, especially to justify slavery and racism, interpretations that have no basis in the text. The point of the episode is simpler and more painful: sin survived the flood. Even the man through whom humanity was preserved is still a sinner. Drunkenness, family dysfunction, and curses all reappear in the very first generation after the flood. The flood washed away the world's wickedness but not the wickedness in the human heart. A deeper solution will be needed.

STEP 5

Connection

Yesterday we saw the flood as judgment and the ark as preservation. Today we see the covenant that follows: God's commitment to maintain the world so that the story of redemption can unfold. The Noahic Covenant is the foundation of all common grace, every harvest, every season, every birth in every culture is a gift under this covenant. It is also the foundation on which the later covenants with Abraham, Moses, and David will be built. Without a stable world, there is no Israel, no land, no temple, no Bethlehem. And when Christ comes, he will fulfill not only the special covenants of grace but will reveal himself as the true Lord of the natural order, calming storms, multiplying food, raising the dead. The renewed creation that the Noahic Covenant points to will be fully realized in the new heavens and new earth.

STEP 6

Application

Today, recognize and respond to common grace. Every meal you eat, every breath you take, every sunrise you witness is a gift under the Noahic Covenant. God is patiently sustaining the world, including the parts of it that are still in rebellion against him, so that the gospel can reach more people, so that more sinners can be brought into the family of God. The reason your unbelieving neighbor's garden grows is the same as why yours does: God's faithfulness to the covenant he made with Noah.

This has practical implications. First, you can enjoy creation without guilt. The pleasures of food, music, beauty, friendship, work, these are gifts of common grace, given to all humanity, including you. Receive them with thanksgiving. Second, you can affirm what is good and true in the wider world without compromising your faith. When unbelievers do beautiful work, in art, science, justice, medicine, parenting, they are operating under common grace, and their work can be honored as such. Third, you can have hope for a world that often seems to be falling apart. The Noahic Covenant is still in force. God is still preserving creation. The story is not over.

And take seriously the dignity of human life. Genesis 9:6 grounds the sanctity of life in the image of God. Every human being you encounter, born and unborn, weak and strong, in your circle and outside it, bears that image. To diminish a human is to attack God's image. To honor a human is to honor God. Today, look at the people around you with this conviction. Each one is a recipient of common grace, an image-bearer of God, a person for whom Christ died. Treat them accordingly.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for a gift of common grace that you rarely notice, such as the seasons, harvests, or order in the world.

Ask him to help you honor someone you meet today as an image bearer.

Thank him that his patience gives time for the gospel to reach people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 4

"I have set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth."

GENESIS 9:13

DAY 23 · WEEK 4

Genesis 10:1-11:32

Table of nations; Babel and the scattering; Abram introduced

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Reading · 58 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 10:1-11:32. This is the longest single reading of Unit 2, but it moves quickly because much of it is genealogy. The two chapters fit together: chapter 10 lists the nations that descend from Noah's three sons, chapter 11 explains why the nations are scattered and speak different languages. The reading ends with the introduction of Abram, setting up the next unit.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday we saw God establish the Noahic Covenant, a promise to preserve creation despite human sin. Today's reading shows that human sin has not been reset, and the consequences continue to spread. Genesis 10-11 covers the transition from the post-flood world to the calling of Abram. It is the bridge between primeval history and patriarchal history.

These two chapters are a deliberate pair. Chapter 10 (the Table of Nations) lists seventy nations descended from Noah's sons, a panoramic view of how the post-flood world filled up. Chapter 11 then circles back to explain how that scattering happened: the tower of Babel, where humanity's pride attempted to make a name for itself and was scattered by God. The order is intentional, the result before the explanation, the consequence before the cause.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Genesis 10 lists 70 nations descended from Noah's three sons: Japheth (14), Ham (30), and Shem (26). Seventy will become a significant number throughout the Bible.
2. The list is theologically loaded, these are not just family trees but the world's nations as God sees them.

3. Babel/Babylon (in the line of Cush) is highlighted in 10:8-10. The kingdom of Nimrod begins at Babel.
4. Genesis 11:1 makes a striking claim: "the whole earth had one language and the same words." This is the situation before the scattering.
5. Humanity gathers on the plain of Shinar (the same region as Babel) and decides: "let us build ourselves a city and a tower with its top in the heavens, and let us make a name for ourselves."
6. Note the verbs: "let us build… let us make a name." Humanity attempts what only God can rightly do, establish itself and make a name.
7. God "comes down" to see the tower, language of divine condescension, perhaps with a hint of irony at humanity's tiny achievement.
8. God confuses their language so they cannot understand one another. The result is the scattering of the nations.
9. Genesis 11:10-26 is the second post-flood genealogy, narrowing from all nations down to Shem's line, all the way to Terah and Abram.
10. The reading ends with Terah's family in Haran, and Abram set up for the great call that opens the next unit.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 10 and 11 belong together as a single theological unit. They tell us how the world we live in came to be, a world of many nations, many languages, scattered across the globe, and they tell us why. The two chapters together teach us about the unity and diversity of humanity, about the perennial human temptation to self-aggrandizement, and about how God's redemptive plan narrows down to one family in preparation for the next stage of the story.

Genesis 10, sometimes called the Table of Nations, is unique in ancient literature. No other ancient civilization produced a document like it, a genealogical map of the entire known world, organized around three brothers and seventy descendants. The number seventy is significant. It will reappear in the seventy elders who go up with Moses (Exodus 24), the seventy who descend to Egypt with Jacob (Genesis 46:27), and the seventy disciples Jesus sends out in Luke 10. The implication is that God's view of "the nations" is comprehensive but not chaotic. There is order, even in a scattered world.

But Genesis 10 also contains a quiet hint of trouble. In verses 8-10, we are told that Nimrod, a descendant of Ham, became "a mighty hunter before the LORD," and that "the beginning of his kingdom was Babel, Erech, Accad, and Calneh, in the land of Shinar." Babel, and the land of Shinar, will appear again in chapter 11 as the place where humanity organizes itself against God. Nimrod is the first empire-builder in the Bible, and his domain is the same domain that will become Babylon, the great archetypal enemy of God's people throughout Scripture. The shadow is already falling.

Then chapter 11 explains how the scattering of the nations actually happened. Verse 1 sets the scene: "the whole earth had one language and the same words." This is the pre-Babel world, unified, with shared communication. Then humanity migrates to the plain of Shinar and proposes a building project. The language is striking. "Let us build ourselves a city and a tower with its top in the heavens, and let us make a name for ourselves." Three verbs in one sentence: let us build, let us make a name, lest we be dispersed. Each of these is a usurpation. Humanity is meant to be fruitful and multiply across the earth (Genesis 1:28; 9:1), but they are gathering in one place. Humanity is meant to receive a name from God (Adam was named by God; Eve was named by Adam, but in submission to God's word), but they are making a name for themselves. Humanity is meant to fill the earth, but they are trying to avoid being dispersed.

The tower itself is a profound theological symbol. A tower "with its top in the heavens" is an assault on the boundary between heaven and earth. It is an attempt to ascend to where God dwells, on humanity's own terms, by humanity's own engineering. It is the sin of Eden in architectural form, "you will be like God", repeated on a civilizational scale. And the motive is pride: "let us make a name for ourselves." The reason God's people make a name for themselves at all in Scripture is when God gives them a name. To make a name for yourself is to claim what only God can give.

God's response is gracious irony. "And the LORD came down to see the city and the tower" (verse 5). The tower whose top was in the heavens is so small that God has to come down to see it. The pride of humanity is reduced to its true scale. And then God acts. He confuses their language, and they cannot understand one another, and the project collapses. Humanity is scattered across the face of the earth, which is what they were supposed to do all along.

But the chapter does not end in judgment. Verses 10-26 narrow the focus down. From all the nations of chapter 10, we are now tracing one line, Shem's descendants. From Shem to Eber (whose name probably gives us "Hebrew"), from Eber to Peleg, all the way to Terah, who fathers Abram, Nahor, and Haran. The genealogy is selective and deliberate. The whole

world has been mapped in chapter 10. The whole world has been scattered in chapter 11. And now the redemptive story is going to narrow to one man, Abram, through whom all the scattered nations of the earth will eventually be blessed.

This narrowing is not a contraction of God's purposes. It is the strategy by which his purposes will reach all the nations. God will not save the world by addressing all nations equally. He will save the world by calling one man, forming one nation, fulfilling his promises through one descendant, who will then bring blessing back to all the families of the earth. The pattern is set here in Genesis 11 and will define the rest of the biblical story.

STEP 5

Connection

Unit 2 has traced the trajectory of sin in the post-Eden, post-Fall world. Genesis 4 showed it in one family, Cain and Abel. Genesis 5 showed it as the universal experience of death across generations. Genesis 6-9 showed it overflowing into corruption, then judgment, then preserved by covenant. Today's reading shows it on a civilizational scale, humanity united in rebellion at Babel, scattered by God, and yet through it all, the line of promise is preserved. The genealogy that ends Genesis 11 sets up Unit 3 perfectly: out of the scattered nations, God will call one man, Abram. Through him, the blessing will eventually come to "all the families of the earth" (Genesis 12:3). Pentecost in Acts 2 will be the great reversal of Babel, when the gospel is preached, the languages are heard, and the nations begin to come back to God through Christ.

STEP 6

Application

The temptation of Babel is not ancient. It is contemporary. "Let us build ourselves a city... and make a name for ourselves." Humans still want to make a name for themselves. Still want to ascend to heaven on their own terms. Still want to gather in unified rebellion against the boundaries God has established. The names of the projects change. The technologies change. The slogans change. But the impulse is the same.

Examine your own ambitions today. What names are you trying to make for yourself? In your career, your relationships, your social presence, your accomplishments, where are you trying to ascend to a place where you can stand without need of God? The Christian life is not about achieving namelessness; it is about receiving the name God gives. Abram becomes Abraham. Jacob becomes Israel. Simon becomes Peter. Saul becomes Paul. And every believer is given the name of Christ. The name you are seeking is already being offered, freely. Let go of the tower.

There is also a positive application. The scattering of Babel was a judgment, but it was also a strategy. By dispersing humanity, God set up the long story by which the gospel would one day reach every nation. At Pentecost, the curse of Babel was beginning to be reversed, people from every nation under heaven heard the gospel in their own language. The Great Commission picks up where Babel left off: go to all the nations, baptize them, teach them. The diversity of the nations is not a problem to be undone; it is a stage on which the glory of God's redemption can be displayed.

If you are part of a church today, you are part of the answer to Babel. The blood of Christ has begun to do what scattered languages could never undo, bring people together not into a single tower of pride but into a single body of grace. Pray for the gospel to keep doing this. And live in the awareness that your role, however small it feels, is part of the great reversal that began at Pentecost and will be consummated when the nations gather around the throne of the Lamb.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess any tower you have been building to make a name for yourself.
- Ask him to help you rest in the name he gives you in Christ.
- Pray for people from nations and languages that are not yours, that they would be gathered in.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 4

"I have set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth."

GENESIS 9:13

DAY 24 · WEEK 4

Psalm 36:5-12

Steadfast love reaches to the heavens, common grace celebrated

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 36:5-12 slowly, twice. This is the second half of Psalm 36, the first half describes the wicked, the second half praises God's steadfast love. Today's portion is the praise section. Read it as the appropriate response to all we have seen in Genesis 4-11: in a world of human wickedness, God's love reaches to the heavens.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

We have just spent six days walking through the bleakest portion of the early Bible, Cain's murder of Abel, the universal spread of death in Genesis 5, the corruption of all flesh in Genesis 6, the flood, the post-flood failure of Noah, and finally the pride of Babel. The human story so far has not been encouraging. We have seen humanity in rebellion at every scale: individual, family, civilization, world.

Today's psalm reminds us that the bleakness of human sin is not the last word. God's steadfast love is bigger. His faithfulness reaches to the clouds. His righteousness is like the mountains. His justice is like the great deep. In a world of Cains and Lamechs and Babels, God's love runs deeper than human evil ever can.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 5: "Your steadfast love, O LORD, extends to the heavens, your faithfulness to the clouds." The vertical scale of God's love matches the vertical attempts at Babel, but God truly reaches the heavens.
2. Verse 6: God's righteousness is "like the mountains of God," his judgments "like the great deep." The natural world is the measure of his moral attributes.

3. Verse 6 ends with a beautiful inclusion: “man and beast you save, O LORD.” Common grace is in view, God’s care extends to all creatures.
4. Verse 7: “How precious is your steadfast love, O God! The children of mankind take refuge in the shadow of your wings.” Image of a mother bird sheltering her young.
5. Verses 8-9 use feast and water imagery: “they feast on the abundance of your house… For with you is the fountain of life; in your light do we see light.”
6. Verse 9 contains one of the most theologically rich lines in the Psalms: “in your light do we see light.” Knowledge of God comes through God himself.
7. The psalm closes with a prayer that God will preserve his people from the wicked and ensure the downfall of evildoers, fitting after the chapters we just read.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 36:5-12 is one of the most expansive descriptions of God’s love in the entire Psalter. After the first half of the psalm describes the wicked, those who flatter themselves, who plot evil on their beds, who do not reject what is evil, the second half lifts our eyes upward to behold something greater than human wickedness: the steadfast love of God himself.

Notice the vertical movement of verse 5: “Your steadfast love, O LORD, extends to the heavens, your faithfulness to the clouds.” Right after we have just read about humanity building a tower whose “top is in the heavens” (Genesis 11:4), this psalm announces that God’s love is what actually reaches the heavens. The Babel-builders tried to make their name reach to the clouds. They failed. But God’s faithfulness already reaches there. The human pride that tried to bridge heaven and earth from below is unnecessary, because God’s love has already bridged it from above.

The next image is equally striking. “Your righteousness is like the mountains of God, your judgments are like the great deep.” God’s character is given the scale of creation itself. His righteousness is mountainous, solid, immovable, towering. His judgments are deep, beyond human plumbing, profound, unsearchable. We do not measure God’s morality by our own intuitions. We measure our intuitions by his unchanging character. And both of these, the heights of his love and the depths of his judgments, are realities we can stake our lives on.

Then verse 6 ends with a sentence that lands with extra weight after the readings of Unit 2: “Man and beast you save, O LORD.” Save. The Hebrew word is yasha, the same root from which we get the name Yeshua, Jesus. God saves not only humans but animals. He cares for all his creatures. After the flood narrative, where animals were taken into the ark, after the Noahic Covenant which explicitly includes “every living creature”, this verse rings with theological weight. God’s saving care extends across all his creation.

Verse 7 introduces one of the most tender images in the Psalter. “How precious is your steadfast love, O God! The children of mankind take refuge in the shadow of your wings.” This is the image of a mother bird sheltering her chicks under her outstretched wings. Jesus will use this very image later in his lament over Jerusalem (Matthew 23:37): “How often would I have gathered your children together as a hen gathers her brood under her wings, and you would not!” The God of Psalm 36 is the God of Christ, the one who longs to gather his people under his protection.

Then comes a feast. Verse 8: “They feast on the abundance of your house, and you give them drink from the river of your delights.” This is hospitality. God does not merely tolerate his people; he feeds them lavishly. The “river of your delights” (Hebrew Eden, the very word!) recalls the garden of Eden and its rivers of life. What was lost in the Fall is offered again to those who take refuge in God. The original garden has not been forgotten; it is being recovered for those who come to him.

Then verse 9 lands as one of the most theologically dense lines in all of Scripture: “For with you is the fountain of life; in your light do we see light.” Both parts of this verse contain entire theologies. Life itself flows from God, he is the fountain, the source, the spring. Apart from him, there is no life. And we see light only by his light. Knowledge of God is not human achievement; it is divine self-revelation. We do not climb up to see God; he shines down so that we can see him. This is the doctrine of revelation in eight words.

The psalm closes with a prayer that God will continue his steadfast love to those who know him, and that the wicked will not have the final word. This is exactly the right prayer after Unit 2. We have seen the wicked, Cain, the world before the flood, the Babel-builders. We have seen God’s patience and grace. And now we pray, with the psalmist, that God’s steadfast love will continue, and that the trajectory of the wicked will end in judgment, while the trajectory of those who know God will end in light.

STEP 5

Connection

Six days ago we read about Cain, whose anger was not ruled. Today’s psalm describes those who “have no fear of God before their eyes” (the first half of Psalm 36, not in our reading), Cain’s spiritual descendants. But after the description of wickedness comes the description of God’s love, and it is overwhelming. After all we have read in Unit 2, the spread of sin, the flood, Babel, this psalm is the appropriate worship. Yes, the world is full of human wickedness. But God’s love reaches to the heavens. His faithfulness to the clouds. His righteousness like mountains. His judgments like the great deep. The God of common grace, who preserves creation under the Noahic Covenant, is the God whose love is bigger than every evil we have witnessed.

STEP 6

Application

The psalmist's response to wickedness is not despair, and not vengeance. It is to lift his eyes to the steadfast love of God. This is a learnable habit. When you read the news, when you face conflict in relationships, when you see injustice that grieves you, you have a choice. You can let your soul shrink down to the size of the wickedness in front of you, or you can lift your eyes to the love of God that reaches to the heavens. The wicked are real. So is God's steadfast love. Choose which one you will let define your day.

Practically, take verse 9 with you today. "In your light do we see light." We do not see clearly by our own effort. We see by God's light. This applies to almost every dimension of the Christian life. We do not understand Scripture by our own intelligence; we understand it by the illumination of the Spirit. We do not pray well by our own ability; we pray well by the Spirit who teaches us to cry "Abba, Father." We do not love well by our own willpower; we love well by the love of God poured into our hearts. The light is his, given to us. Receive it.

And consider the image of taking refuge in the shadow of God's wings. In a world where everything feels exposed, where reputations can be destroyed by a single tweet, where lives can be unraveled by a single accident, God offers shadow. Hiddenness. Protection. The Christian is not asked to be impressive in the world's eyes. The Christian is invited to be hidden under God's wings, fed at his table, given to drink from his river. This is your inheritance in Christ. Today, claim it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God for steadfast love that is bigger than the wickedness you see, including your own.

Ask him to hide you in the shadow of his wings today.

Pray that in his light you would see yourself, the world, and Christ more truly.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 4

"I have set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth."

GENESIS 9:13

DAY 25 · WEEK 4

Psalm 33:10-22

The LORD frustrates the plans of nations, sovereign over Babel

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 33:10-22 slowly, twice. This is the second half of Psalm 33, earlier in this plan we read verses 1-9, which praised God for creation. Today's portion turns to God's sovereignty over the nations and his particular care for his people. It is the perfect Psalm after the scattering of Babel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Two days ago we read the tower of Babel, humanity united in pride against God, scattered in confusion. Today's psalm gives us the divine perspective on the affairs of nations. From God's vantage point, the schemes of humans are nothing. The plans of kings come to nothing apart from his will. And yet, the God who frustrates the proud also watches faithfully over those who fear him. This psalm is the right meditation after the events of Genesis 11.

We read Psalm 33:1-9 on an earlier day in this plan. That section celebrated creation by God's word. Today's half completes the meditation by showing that the same God who created by his word governs history by his sovereignty.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 10: "The LORD brings the counsel of the nations to nothing; he frustrates the plans of the peoples." Babel is exactly this, counsel of nations brought to nothing.
2. Verse 11: "The counsel of the LORD stands forever, the plans of his heart to all generations." Contrast, human plans fail, God's plans endure.
3. Verse 12: "Blessed is the nation whose God is the LORD, the people whom he has chosen as his heritage!" Election language, God chooses a people.

4. Verses 13-15: God looks down from heaven and sees ALL the children of man. He fashions their hearts. He observes their deeds.
5. Verses 16-17: “The king is not saved by his great army… the war horse is a false hope.” Military power is unreliable apart from God.
6. Verse 18: “Behold, the eye of the LORD is on those who fear him, on those who hope in his steadfast love.” His attention is fixed on his people.
7. Verse 19: God delivers from death and keeps alive in famine. Common life-preservation under the Noahic Covenant.
8. Verses 20-22 close in waiting: “Our soul waits for the LORD; he is our help and our shield.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 33:10-22 picks up where the first half left off. Verses 1-9 praised God for creating by his word. Now the focus shifts to God’s sovereign rule over history, and to his particular care for the people who fear him.

Verse 10 lands with extra weight after our reading of Genesis 11. “The LORD brings the counsel of the nations to nothing; he frustrates the plans of the peoples.” Babel is the paradigm example of this verse in action. Humanity united in counsel, “let us build a tower”, and God brought the counsel to nothing in a single act of language-confusion. The verse is not nostalgic about Babel; it is descriptive of God’s ongoing sovereignty. Every empire that has ever risen against God has eventually come to nothing. Babylon. Assyria. Persia. Rome. Every modern attempt to construct human autonomy apart from God ends in the same way, sooner or later, in confusion and scattering.

But the verse is followed immediately by its inverse. Verse 11: “The counsel of the LORD stands forever, the plans of his heart to all generations.” The same sovereignty that frustrates human plans establishes God’s plans. History is not a contest between God’s purposes and humanity’s purposes that might go either way. God’s plans are unshakeable. They will endure when every empire has fallen. This is not a depressing verse for the believer; it is the most hope-filled verse imaginable. The plans of God’s heart, including his plan to redeem you, to keep you, to bring you safely home, will stand forever.

Verse 12 then makes a particular claim: “Blessed is the nation whose God is the LORD, the people whom he has chosen as his heritage!” In Old Testament context, this referred primarily to Israel. But in the New Testament, the apostle Peter applies this language to the

church: “you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession” (1 Peter 2:9). The church is now the people whom God has chosen as his heritage. The blessing of verse 12 belongs to every believer who is in Christ.

Verses 13-15 give us the vantage point of the King of heaven. “The LORD looks down from heaven; he sees all the children of man; from where he sits enthroned he looks out on all the inhabitants of the earth.” Nothing escapes his gaze. Babel’s tower was not impressive to him; the present rebellions of contemporary humanity are not impressive to him either. From his throne, he sees everything, knows everything, fashions every heart, observes every deed. This is sobering for the wicked. It is comforting for the faithful. You are seen. By the God who matters.

Then verses 16-17 deliver one of the great political theology passages of the Psalter. “The king is not saved by his great army; a warrior is not delivered by his great strength. The war horse is a false hope for salvation, and by its great might it cannot rescue.” This is a stunning claim in the ancient Near East. Every nation around Israel boasted in its military strength. Israel was tiny by comparison. And the psalmist says, plainly: military might does not save. Armies are not the deciding factor. War horses are not the source of victory. The Lord is. Whatever strength a king or nation has is temporary, contingent, and ultimately useless against the will of God.

Then verse 18 brings us to the warm center of the psalm. “Behold, the eye of the LORD is on those who fear him, on those who hope in his steadfast love.” The same God whose eye sweeps over the whole earth has his eye fixed in particular on those who fear him. His attention is not divided thinly across humanity. It is concentrated on his people. Those who fear him, who hope in his steadfast love, they are watched, kept, loved with focused attention.

And what does God do for them? Verse 19: “that he may deliver their soul from death and keep them alive in famine.” This is the Noahic Covenant language at the personal level. God preserves life. He delivers from death. He keeps his people alive through times when others perish. This is true at the temporal level (sometimes God protects believers from physical disasters), and it is supremely true at the spiritual level (the eternal life he gives in Christ delivers from the second death and keeps the believer alive forever).

The psalm closes with a posture of waiting. “Our soul waits for the LORD; he is our help and our shield. For our heart is glad in him, because we trust in his holy name. Let your steadfast love, O LORD, be upon us, even as we hope in you.” The Christian life is, in large part, a posture of waiting, waiting for promises to be fulfilled, for prayers to be answered, for the final consummation of all things. But it is not anxious waiting. It is glad waiting, trusting waiting, hoping waiting. We wait because we know whom we are waiting for.

STEP 5

Connection

Today's psalm is the divine perspective on yesterday's reading. Where Genesis 11 showed us Babel from the ground, humans plotting, building, getting scattered, Psalm 33 shows us Babel from heaven. God sees the counsel of the nations and brings it to nothing. His own counsel stands forever. And while he scatters the proud, his eye remains on those who fear him. The psalm anticipates everything Unit 3 will develop. God is about to bring the counsel of his heart to bear in human history by calling one man, Abram. From Abram will come Israel, the "nation whose God is the LORD" (verse 12), the heritage God has chosen. And from Israel will come Christ, in whom the chosen heritage now includes every nation that believes.

STEP 6

Application

Live today in the light of God's sovereignty. Two specific applications follow.

First, do not be intimidated by what the world calls power. The psalm is candid: the king is not saved by his great army. The war horse is a false hope. The political powers that loom over your news feed, the cultural forces that seem unstoppable, the corporate behemoths that shape your daily life, none of them is ultimate. God brings the counsel of the nations to nothing. He does it on his own timeline, often invisibly, but he does it. Live as someone who knows this. Do not give your fear to anything that God can dismantle with a thought.

Second, take the comfort of verse 18 into your day. "The eye of the LORD is on those who fear him." If you fear God, if you love him, trust him, follow him, then his eye is on you in particular. Not as a generalized providence that covers everyone equally, but as the focused attention of a Father who has chosen you as his heritage. You are seen. You are watched over. You are not lost in the crowd of humanity. Whatever you are facing today, the eye of the LORD is on you.

And take the posture of verses 20-22. Wait. Trust. Hope. Receive God's steadfast love. The Christian life is not a sprint to fix everything that is wrong. It is a long walk of waiting on the LORD who is your help and your shield. Be glad in him today. Trust his holy name. Let his steadfast love be upon you, even as you hope in him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what feels out of control in your life or the world right now.

Thank him that nothing escapes his sight and nothing thwarts his purposes.

Ask him for a soul that waits for him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 4

"I have set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth."

GENESIS 9:13

DAY 26 · WEEK 4

Psalm 9

I will give thanks; God judges the world in righteousness

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 9 slowly, twice. This is a longer Psalm, twenty verses, but it moves quickly. As you read, notice how the Psalm alternates between thanksgiving for God's past faithfulness and prayer about God's future judgment. It is a fitting Psalm to close out the meditations of Unit 2.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

We are at the end of Unit 2. We have walked through the spread of sin in the post-flood world, the catastrophe of the flood itself, the Noahic Covenant of preservation, and the pride and scattering of Babel. Throughout, we have seen a particular pattern: human evil is real, judgment is real, but God's faithfulness to preserve his people and his world is also real. Today's psalm gathers up many of these threads in worship.

Psalm 9 is attributed to David, sung "to the tune of Muth-labben," the meaning of which is uncertain. The psalm celebrates God's righteous judgment of the nations and his vindication of the oppressed. It is the perfect Old Testament prayer for those who have just been reading about humanity in rebellion.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with whole-hearted thanksgiving: "I will give thanks to the LORD with my whole heart; I will recount all of your wonderful deeds."
2. Verses 4-6 describe past acts of divine judgment: God has rebuked the nations, the wicked have perished, their cities have been overthrown.
3. Verse 7 is theological: "The LORD sits enthroned forever; he has established his throne for justice." Justice is built into the throne itself.

4. Verse 8: “He judges the world with righteousness; he judges the peoples with uprightness.” Universal scope, all nations, with perfect justice.
5. Verse 9: “The LORD is a stronghold for the oppressed, a stronghold in times of trouble.” Justice for the wicked is mercy for the oppressed.
6. Verse 10: “Those who know your name put their trust in you, for you, O LORD, have not forsaken those who seek you.” Knowing God’s name leads to trust.
7. Verses 11-12 are about declaring God’s deeds to the nations, taking the message outward.
8. Verses 15-16: The wicked are caught in the nets they set for others. Justice is poetic, sin returns on itself.
9. Verse 17: “The wicked shall return to Sheol, all the nations that forget God.” Forgetting God has eschatological consequences.
10. Verse 18 is the great hinge: “For the needy shall not always be forgotten, and the hope of the poor shall not perish forever.”
11. The psalm closes with a prayer for God to arise and judge, “Let the nations know that they are but men.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 9 is a song about the justice of God, sung by someone who has seen enough of human wickedness to want it. It is honest about evil and confident about God’s response. It is exactly the right psalm after Unit 2.

The psalm opens with thanksgiving, but notice what David is thankful for. He is thankful for God’s “wonderful deeds.” And as you read on, those wonderful deeds include God’s acts of judgment against the wicked. This sets a tone that may feel strange to modern ears. We tend to be uncomfortable with celebrating divine judgment. But the psalmist is not uncomfortable. To him, God’s judgment of the wicked is something worth singing about, because it means the oppressed are vindicated, the world is being put right, and the king of justice is on his throne.

Verse 7 captures the heart of the psalm’s theology: “The LORD sits enthroned forever; he has established his throne for justice.” Justice is not a peripheral concern for God. It is built into the foundation of his kingship. He does not occasionally judge; he reigns from a throne whose central purpose is judgment. And the next verse expands the scope: “He judges the world with righteousness; he judges the peoples with uprightness.” This is universal. Every nation. Every person. All judged by God’s perfect standard, in his perfect time.

But here is where the psalm reframes everything. The judgment of the wicked is the salvation of the oppressed. Verse 9: "The LORD is a stronghold for the oppressed, a stronghold in times of trouble." The same God who is terrifying to the proud is a refuge for the broken. The same justice that frightens the comfortable is good news for the abused, the forgotten, the powerless. If you are tempted to wish God were less just, ask yourself what you are wishing for. A God who does not judge is a God who does not care about the oppressed. A God who never punishes is a God who never vindicates. The justice of God is the hope of the poor.

Verse 10 introduces a tender phrase: "Those who know your name put their trust in you." Knowing God's name is biblical shorthand for knowing God personally. To know his name is to know who he really is, his character, his promises, his commitments. And to know him is to trust him. People do not trust strangers. They trust people they know. The reason some people do not trust God is that they do not yet know him. The reason believers can trust him even in dark times is that they have come to know his name.

Then comes the great social vision of the psalm in verses 11-12 and 16-18. The God who judges remembers the blood of the oppressed. He does not forget the cry of the afflicted. The needy will not always be forgotten. The hope of the poor will not perish forever. These verses are the seedbed of the entire prophetic tradition in the Old Testament, where the prophets thunder against injustice on God's behalf. They are also the foundation of the church's commitment to the poor and the oppressed. The God we worship is the God who hears the cry of the needy.

There is also a fascinating image of poetic justice in verses 15-16. "The nations have sunk in the pit that they made; in the net that they hid, their own foot has been caught. The LORD has made himself known; he has executed judgment; the wicked are snared in the work of their own hands." Evil has a way of consuming those who practice it. The traps set for others entangle their setters. The systems built to oppress eventually collapse on those who built them. This is not karma in an impersonal sense; it is the moral grain of the universe set by God. Sin destroys those who indulge it. The wicked are not so much punished by God as left to be destroyed by their own choices.

The psalm closes with a prayer: "Arise, O LORD! Let not man prevail; let the nations be judged before you! Put them in fear, O LORD! Let the nations know that they are but men!" This is a strong prayer, and it should feel strong in our mouths. It is a prayer for God to be God, for him to step in, judge the nations, and remind them of their creatureliness. After reading about Babel, this prayer feels exactly right. The nations have forgotten that they are but men. We pray that God will remind them.

STEP 5

Connection

Unit 2 has shown us human sin at every scale, individual (Cain), familial (Noah's drunkenness), civilizational (Babel). Psalm 9 is the appropriate prayer in response. We have seen the wicked, and we cry out for justice. We have seen God's preservation through covenant, and we give thanks. We have seen the oppressed of every era, those crushed by Lamechs and Nimrods, and we trust that God will not forget them. The psalm anticipates everything Unit 3 will develop: God arises, the nations are judged, and one man (Abram) is called to be the beginning of God's plan to bless the very nations that have rebelled against him.

STEP 6

Application

Today, let this Psalm shape three things in you.

First, your view of God's justice. Many modern Christians have unconsciously absorbed the idea that God's judgment is embarrassing or harsh, something to apologize for. The psalmist shows us a different posture. Divine justice is something to thank God for. It is the foundation of his throne. It is the hope of the oppressed. If you struggle with the doctrine of God's wrath, read this Psalm and ask why the people of God have sung it joyfully for three thousand years. The answer is that they knew what we sometimes forget: justice is mercy when it is directed at oppression.

Second, your view of God's care for the oppressed. The God of Psalm 9 hears the cry of the afflicted. He does not forget the blood of the oppressed. The needy shall not always be forgotten. This commits the believer to active concern for those who suffer in this world. If God remembers the oppressed, his people cannot pretend not to see them. Today, ask yourself: who in your life is being forgotten? In your church, your neighborhood, your city, your family? The God you worship sees them. Let your eyes see them too.

Third, your view of your own situation. If you are facing injustice today, at work, in your family, in your community, Psalm 9 is your prayer. The LORD is a stronghold for the oppressed. He has not forsaken those who seek him. The traps set for you will, in God's time, fall on the heads of those who set them. You do not have to retaliate, because justice is not your job. Justice is God's throne. Trust him. Wait for him. Sing his praise. And know that the same God who judged Babel will, in his time, vindicate every faithful sufferer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give thanks to God with your whole heart, naming something he has done.

Ask him to help you trust him more fully as you know him better.

Pray for someone who is poor or oppressed, and ask what he might have you do.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 4

“I have set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth.”

GENESIS 9:13

DAY 27 · WEEK 4

Review and Reflection

Unit 2 review, Common Grace & the Noahic Covenant

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD."
>
> GENESIS 6:8

REST

Meditation

Today there is no new reading. Today is for review and reflection on what you have learned in Unit 2.

Begin by memorizing the verse above if you have not already. Genesis 6:8 is the hinge of the entire Noah narrative. Surrounding this single sentence is the bleakest assessment of humanity in the Old Testament (verse 5: "every intention of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually") and the announcement of the coming flood (verse 7). But in the middle of judgment, this one verse stands out: "But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD."

This is the first occurrence of the Hebrew word hen, favor, or grace, in the Bible. Everything that the New Testament will say about salvation by grace is anticipated here. Noah did not earn favor. He did not negotiate for favor. He found it. Grace, by definition, is what is found, not what is achieved.

Say this verse aloud several times today. Notice the conjunction: "But Noah found favor." That "but" is everything. In a world of judgment, there is a "but." In a heart of rebellion, there is a "but." That "but" is the difference between being lost with the world and being preserved by grace. The same "but" applies to every believer in Christ, in a world that is, in the language of Romans 1, under the wrath of God, there is a "but" for those who have found favor through faith in Jesus. "But God, being rich in mercy…" (Ephesians 2:4). The story of salvation always turns on that small word.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 2 you have traveled through Genesis 4 to 11, the early chapters of humanity after the Fall. The unit began with Cain's murder of Abel, the first violence in human history, and the warning that "sin is crouching at the door." It then moved through the genealogy of Adam to Noah, where ten generations were punctuated by the repeated phrase "and he died", except for Enoch, who walked with God and was not. The pre-flood corruption of humanity was so total that God resolved to start over, but Noah found favor.

The flood narrative was one of the longer readings of the unit: judgment by water, the ark as a microcosm of creation, the de-creation and re-creation of the world, the great hinge of "God remembered Noah." Then came the Noahic Covenant, God's pledge to preserve creation, including "man and beast," under the sign of the rainbow. This is the foundation of common grace.

The unit's final reading was Genesis 10-11: the Table of Nations showing how the post-flood world filled up, and the tower of Babel showing how quickly human pride re-asserted itself. Humanity tried to make a name for itself; God scattered them. But the chapter ended with the line of Shem narrowing down to Terah and Abram, setting up Unit 3.

The Psalms then taught us how to respond to all of this. Psalm 36 lifted our eyes to God's steadfast love that reaches to the heavens, bigger than every wickedness we had witnessed. Psalm 33 reminded us that God brings the counsel of the nations to nothing while his own counsel stands forever. And Psalm 9 sang the justice of God who hears the cry of the oppressed and reigns from a throne of judgment.

The big theological lessons of this unit are these: Sin spreads from generation to generation, but the line of promise is preserved. Judgment is real and is sometimes severe, but it is always paired with mercy for the faithful. The Noahic Covenant is God's commitment to maintain the world as a stage on which redemption can unfold. Common grace touches every life and every culture, regardless of belief. And underneath every story of rebellion, God is patiently moving toward Abram, through whom blessing will eventually come to all the families of the earth.

REFLECT

Review Questions

How does the story of Cain and Abel show the nature and spread of sin?

Revisit Genesis 4. Sin is shown crouching at the door, an active force seeking to consume. Cain refuses to rule over it, and the result is the first murder. Notice how quickly sin escalates: by Lamech (verses 23-24), the cycle of vengeance has multiplied seventy-sevenfold. Sin is not just an individual failure; it is a multiplying force that ruptures families, communities, and generations. Write a few sentences in your own words about what Genesis 4 teaches you about how sin works.

What is the Noahic covenant, and who does it include?

Read Genesis 9:8-17 again. The Noahic Covenant is God's promise never again to destroy the earth by flood. Notice its scope: it is made with Noah and his descendants, but also with "every living creature" on the earth. This is the most universal of God's covenants. It is also the foundation of common grace, every harvest, every season, every birth in every culture is a gift under this covenant. What does it tell you about God that he extends this covenant to all of creation, even to people who do not believe in him?

What does the tower of Babel reveal about human nature and God's purposes?

Look at Genesis 11:1-9. Humans gathered together to "make a name for ourselves" and to build a tower "with its top in the heavens." Three sins converge in this story: pride (making a name), idolatry (replacing God's name with their own), and disobedience (gathering rather than filling the earth). God's response, confusion of language and scattering, is judgment, but also redemption strategy. Through scattering, God sets up the long story by which the gospel will eventually reach every nation. The reversal begins at Pentecost. How does this shape the way you see the world today?

How does common grace differ from saving grace?

Common grace is the kindness God extends to all humanity, regardless of belief, the rain that falls on the just and the unjust, the harvests, the seasons, the beauty in human cultures, the goodness in human relationships. It is grounded in the Noahic Covenant. Saving grace is the particular grace by which God redeems his elect through Christ, the grace by which Noah found favor in God's eyes, and by which every believer is brought into the family of God. Both are gifts. Both are unearned. But common grace preserves the world; saving grace transforms hearts. Sit with the distinction. How does understanding the difference help you appreciate both the beauty in the unbelieving world and the particular wonder of your own salvation?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for his patience with the world and with you, in your own words.

Thank him for the line of promise that leads to Christ.

Ask him to keep what you learned in this unit alive in how you live.

DAY 28 · WEEK 4

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. Yesterday you completed the Unit 2 review; today closes the week with rest. Take time to let both the doctrinal weight of Unit 2 and the rhythm of weekly Sabbath settle into your heart.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"I have set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth."

GENESIS 9:13

REST

Meditation

The rainbow is the sign of the Noahic Covenant, God's promise never to destroy the earth by flood again. In the ancient Near East, a bow was a weapon. Here, God hangs his bow in the sky with the string pointing AWAY from the earth, as if to say: my weapon of judgment has been laid down.

Every rainbow you have ever seen is a reminder of this covenant, and a promise that God's judgment is not the last word for his world. The covenant is universal in scope, made with "every living creature" on earth. Every harvest, every sunrise, every breath taken on this planet is a gift under this covenant.

Carry this verse with you this week. The next time you see a rainbow, say it. The next time it rains, remember the bow that hangs above the storm. By next week, the verse should be yours.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

The week centered on the Noahic Covenant. You read Genesis 8:20-9:29, Noah's first sacrifice after the flood, God's resolve never to curse the ground again, the institution of the rainbow as covenant sign. You read Genesis 10-11, the Table of Nations and the tower of Babel, humanity's pride scattered into the diverse peoples that the gospel would one day gather. You worshiped through Psalm 36 (God's steadfast love), Psalm 33:10-22 (God's sovereignty over nations), and Psalm 9 (the justice of God who hears the cry of the oppressed). And yesterday you completed the Unit 2 review, with Genesis 6:8 as the anchor, Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD.

The week's theme is the foundation of common grace. Every harvest, every birth in every culture, every flicker of beauty in a fallen world, all of it operates under the Noahic Covenant. God preserves the world he made, so that redemption can unfold within it.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where in your life have you been taking common grace for granted? The Noahic Covenant is the foundation of every meal you eat, every season you enjoy, every breath you draw. These are gifts, not entitlements. Name one specific gift of common grace today, and receive it as such.

How does the Noahic Covenant point you to Christ? God's commitment to preserve the world after the flood was not the end of the story, it was the structural promise that held creation together so that the deeper covenant in Christ could come. The rainbow promises that God's judgment is not final; the cross proves it. Where do you most need the assurance today that judgment is not the final word for those in Christ?

How does the tower of Babel reshape how you see today's news? Humanity still gathers in pride. Humanity still tries to ascend to heaven on its own terms. Humanity still gets scattered. Where in your own life or your culture do you see Babel patterns? Where do you see Pentecost answers?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the rainbow, the seasons, and every harvest, and name one you enjoyed this week.

Ask him to open your eyes to common grace in the days ahead.

Rest in the deeper grace that has reached you in his Son.